

PEOPLES OF AFRICA

AFRICA IS HOME TO about 849 million people – more than one in eight of the world's population. The most densely populated areas are along the northern and western coasts, especially in the fertile valleys of the Nile, Niger, Congo, and Senegal rivers. The population of Africa is growing rapidly, as birth rates in many African countries are extremely high. Families are often large, and about half the population is young, below the age of 15. Although most Africans live in the countryside, a growing number are now found in towns and cities. Many people have moved because of poverty and lack of work in country areas; others have gone to escape civil wars, droughts, and famines.



Richard Leakey discovered some of the earliest known human remains in Africa's Rift Valley.

THE FIRST PEOPLE

The history of human beings would seem to have begun in Africa. The skeletons of people who walked upright and lived up to 2 million years ago have been found in the Rift Valley that runs through Tanzania and Ethiopia. Archeologists now believe that this region was the birthplace of our human ancestors. From here, these early human beings, known as *Homo Erectus*, soon moved into other parts of the continent and rapidly spread even farther afield.

Percentage of population under 15 years of age



Egypt:
49%

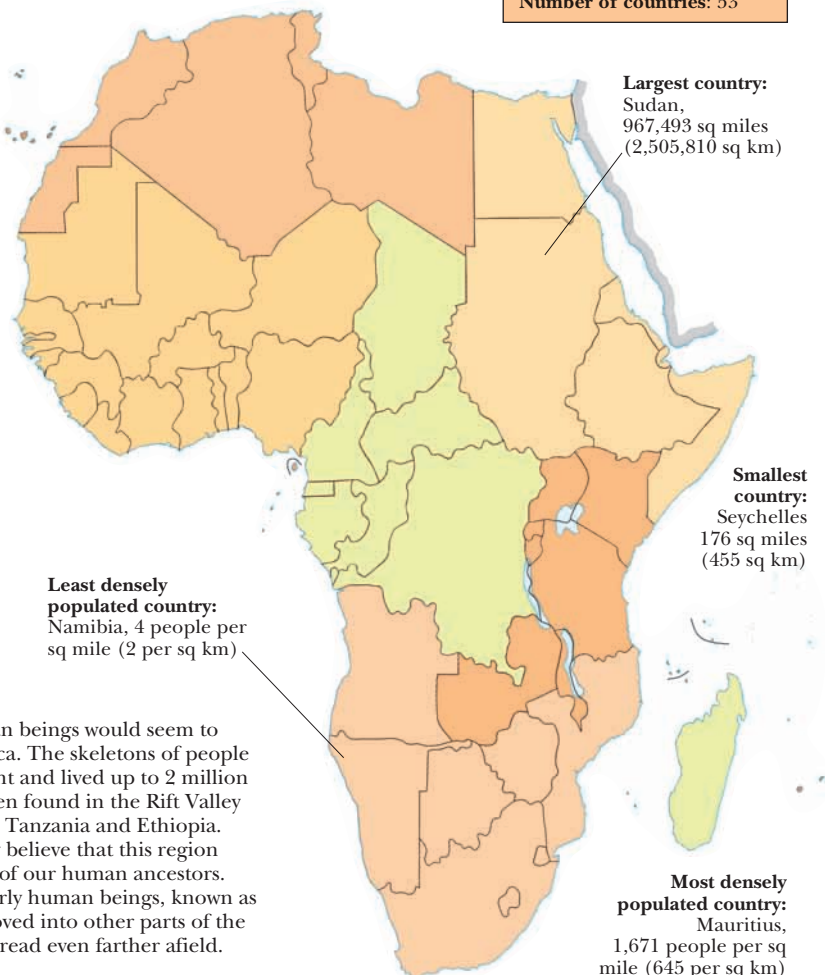
Ghana:
55%

Ethiopia:
60%

Tanzania:
62%

YOUNG POPULATION

The population of Africa is growing rapidly. Improved medicine has generally decreased death rates, while birth rates remain very high. Women in countries such as Angola and Burkina Faso have six children each on average, whereas in North America and Europe they have only one or two. However, HIV infection is fast becoming widespread among young people and is likely to kill many in the near future.



TOWN AND COUNTRY

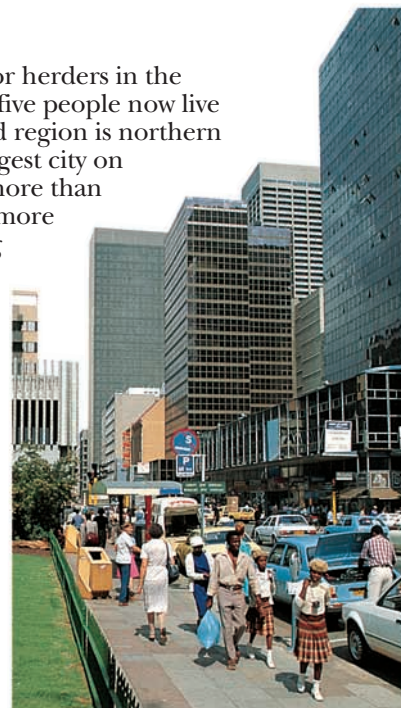
Most African people live as farmers or herders in the countryside. However, about one in five people now live in towns. The most heavily urbanized region is northern Africa, and Cairo, in Egypt, is the largest city on the continent with a population of more than 15 million. Several other cities have more than a million inhabitants, including Addis Ababa in Ethiopia, Kinshasa in the Congo, and Johannesburg in South Africa. The poor often live on the outskirts of the cities, in shantytowns.

BIGGEST URBAN POPULATION

Libya	88%
Djibouti	84%
Gabon	83%
Tunisia	67%
Republic of the Congo	67%

SMALLEST URBAN POPULATION

Rwanda	6%
Burundi	10%
Uganda	15%
Malawi	15%
Ethiopia	16%



Many people go to the cities on a temporary basis in search of work. In Johannesburg, shown here, migrants seek work in the gold and diamond mines.